

OUTLASTING THE SLOWDOWN

TO ASSESS HOW PREPARED START-UPS ARE FOR A FUNDING WINTER, *BT* ANALYSED INDIA'S 100 MOST-FUNDED START-UPS TO ESTIMATE THEIR CASH RUNWAY

BY JYOTINDRA DUBEY

FOR NEARLY A decade, the Indian start-up narrative was defined by valuations. Founders raced to join the Unicorn club, following a simple rule: scale first, outspend the competition, and figure out the bills later.

That party seems to be over and that reckoning has now arrived.

Late-stage funding is slowing sharply, and investor scrutiny has intensified, making survival—not just growth—the central question for start-ups. Cash runway, once a footnote in pitch decks, has emerged as the most critical measure of resilience in a

funding-constrained environment.

As Gopal Jain, Managing Director and CEO of Gaja Capital, puts it, “India’s start-up ecosystem has grown up. The metrics that once drove valuations, such as GMV, user counts, headline funding rounds, have given way to the ones that matter—margins, cash efficiency, and discipline to build for the long term.” According to him, founders today have to treat the runway as a strategic asset. A business with 18-24 months of runway commands negotiating leverage—with investors, customers, and even talent.